

tered. As hard as it can be to end a favorite story, much less a beloved chronicle, letting it go on until players lose interest or it simply runs out of steam is definitely not preferable to finding a suitable ending.

It's also worth noting that a satisfactory resolution refers to the players feeling that the story reached a conclusion that matched their investment in it. It doesn't mean that the characters must triumph and every plot be wrapped up with a neat little bow. In fact, sometimes the best endings are tragic ones. From *Hamlet* to *The Empire Strikes Back* to *The Last of Us*, fiction is full of proof that a dark ending or defeated characters can still mean a satisfactory resolution for the audience, not to mention inspire more questions or even follow-up tales to explore what comes next.

As a story goes on, it's a good idea for the Storyteller to check in with players from time to time to see how they feel

about where they see it ending, or what they'd like to see resolved. While the Storyteller is under no obligation to change his plans to match exactly what they want, it's a good idea to see what the players expect. If everyone is looking forward to a tragic ending, and the Storyteller is planning a happy triumph, the players might actually feel a little bit robbed. Knowing this can allow for some potential changes to satisfy both the Storyteller's plans as well as the players' desires, making for a better experience for everyone.

Likewise, if a player is thinking about retiring her current character to start a new one, the Storyteller can use this information to give the character a satisfactory send off and wrap up any related plot threads. It's a good idea to discuss the character's departure with the player, and see if there are any particular mysteries or subplots the player really wants to see resolved before the character departs. It may not be possible to cover them all, but with enough warning it's usually possible to at least wrap up enough to satisfy the player's desires.

The Death of Dreams

Changelings have two unique possible "endings" for characters that deserve special mention — coming Undone from Banality, and descending into Bedlam due to unchecked exposure to Glamour. As both of these represent highly tragic and disturbing ends for a character, it is a good idea for a Storyteller to talk to a player whose character is heading in either direction, and see if he's willing to see such a dark fate play out or if he'd rather retire his character before reaching that point.

A changeling coming Undone is an exceedingly tragic circumstance, as everything magical and wonderful about them is permanently extinguished (at least in this lifetime). An Undone character doesn't even get a glorious send off, but fades into normalcy, forgetting their Kithain friends and their chimerical adventures, becoming just another face in the crowd. It's a powerful conclusion for a character's story, but can be simply too tragic for some players to think of it befalling a beloved character, at least "onscreen" during play.

By contrast, a changeling succumbing to Bedlam is horrific in an entirely different way, warping her into a chimerical nightmare of her former self. She becomes something less of a person and more of an urban legend, the kind of tale that other Kithain use to frighten their children. Even a "benevolent" individual fallen into Bedlam is a dangerous creature, for she has lost all notions of mortal empathy or morality. She might fake them, at least well enough to lure in an unsuspecting target, but she does not truly feel them, not one bit. Becoming the sort of creature other changelings hunt and fear, possibly even an antagonist in her own right, is not a fate some players are willing to stomach for their characters.

Advanced Storytelling Techniques

What follows is a small sampling of Storytelling techniques that can be a bit tricky to pull off, requiring a bit of extra thought and preparation to enact, but that also offer some unique experiences and interesting perspectives for those willing to attempt them. This is by no means an exhaustive list, but hopefully should serve to inspire some unconventional tales to keep players excited.

In Media Res

Meaning "in the middle of things," this technique involves opening a story in the middle of an action sequence or other dramatic situation. Doing so gets the attention of the players immediately and gets things off to an exciting start, though it's important to still provide enough information for the players to understand at least the basics of what's going on, or the action will stall out in confusion instead of hurtling forward as intended.

Flashback/Cut-Away

A flashback involves momentarily stepping back in time to see past events — or current events happening elsewhere, in the case of a cut-away — in order to shed more light on a current situation. Some of these scenes may be purely narrative, with the Storyteller simply describing events, while others may be more interactive, with players temporarily taking on roles of individuals in the past. (Though if it becomes too intricate this becomes a frame tale, as described below.) Unless it's discovered in-character, the information in these scenes is strictly for the players, not the characters, and is shared in the interest of increasing tension.

Frame Tale

Also known as a story within a story, this technique involves telling one or more stories inside the main one, which still serve to advance the action of the primary tale. These other stories typically spotlight the mood or theme of the main piece, as well as provide necessary insight to conclude the main